

Successful Pioneers

By 1910, aviation pioneers in Europe were competing strongly with the US, where the Wright Brothers' legal battles with competitors had delayed progress. There were triplanes, biplanes, and especially light, maneuverable monoplanes. Louis Blériot's successful crossing of the English Channel in 1909 brought a sea change in popular perception of aviation as a practical possibility, rather than just a dangerous adventure for wealthy eccentrics.

▷ Santos-Dumont Demoiselle Type 20 1908

Origin France

Engine 35 hp Darracq water-cooled flat-twin

Top speed 56 mph (90 km/h)

Brazilian aviator Alberto Santos-Dumont developed the ultralight, bamboo-fuselage Demoiselle (Damsselfly) and released the plans for free; it was claimed one could be built for under 500 French francs.



△ Voisin Biplane 1907

Origin France

Engine 50 hp Antoinette water-cooled V8

Top speed 35 mph (56 km/h)

Gabriel Voisin built aircraft from 1904. Henry Farman flew a Voisin biplane to win the prize for the first 0.62 miles (1km) circular flight on January 13, 1908. Some 60 more were built; this is a replica.



△ Blériot Type XI 1909

Origin France

Engine 24 hp Anzani air-cooled 3-cylinder fan

Top speed 47 mph (76 km/h)

On July 25, 1909, Louis Blériot and this aircraft made the first heavier-than-air flight over the English Channel, taking 36.5 minutes. Within two months he had taken 103 orders for Type XIs.



△ Avro Triplane IV 1910

Origin UK

Engine 35 hp Green water-cooled 4-cylinder in-line

Top speed 45 mph (72 km/h)

Alliott Verdon Roe built triplanes from 1907, culminating in a simpler single-tailplane, wing-warping trainer for the Avro Flying School at Brooklands, UK; this is a 1960s replica.



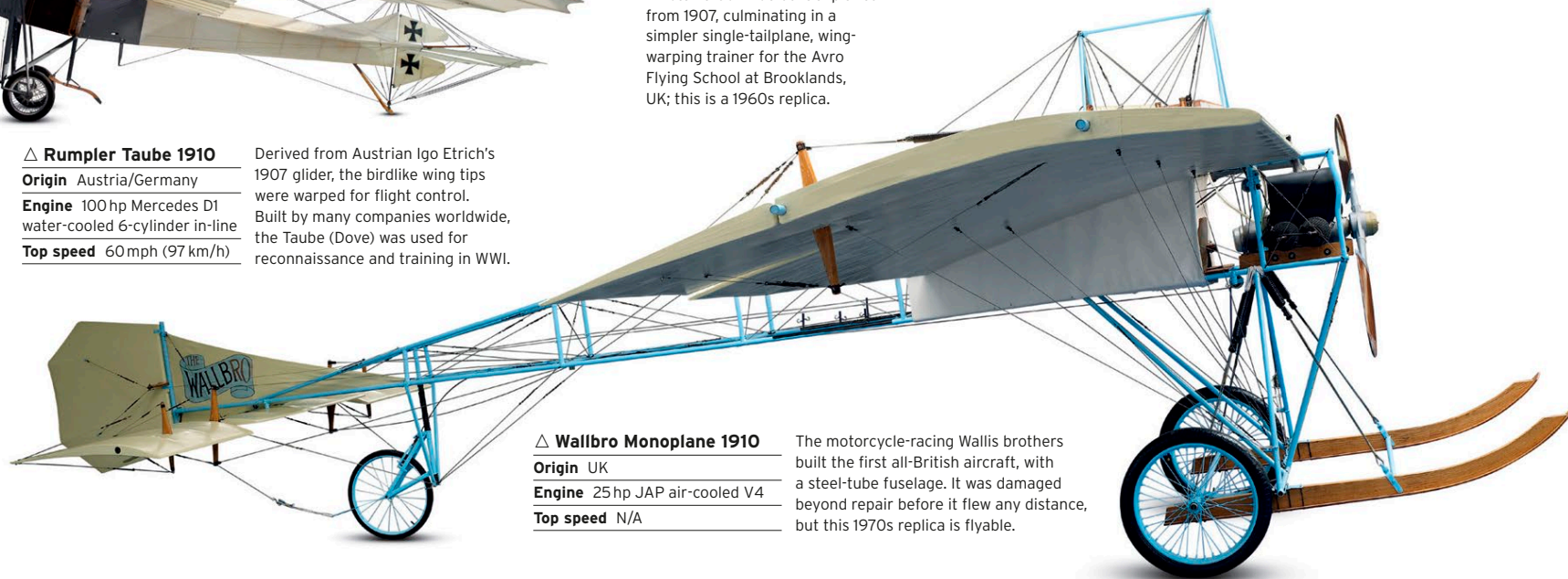
△ Rumpler Taube 1910

Origin Austria/Germany

Engine 100 hp Mercedes D1 water-cooled 6-cylinder in-line

Top speed 60 mph (97 km/h)

Derived from Austrian Igo Etrich's 1907 glider, the birdlike wing tips were warped for flight control. Built by many companies worldwide, the Taube (Dove) was used for reconnaissance and training in WWI.



△ Wallbro Monoplane 1910

Origin UK

Engine 25 hp JAP air-cooled V4

Top speed N/A

The motorcycle-racing Wallis brothers built the first all-British aircraft, with a steel-tube fuselage. It was damaged beyond repair before it flew any distance, but this 1970s replica is flyable.